♠ ♥ ♦ ♣ All Fives ♣ ♦ ♥ ♠

A natural, disciplined bidding system built on common sense.

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Philosophy

- **No crazy openings.** Bids mean what they look like.
- **Partner is reliable.** Trust his bids.
- **Use the opponents' information.**
- **Stay flexible.** This is an experimental system.
- **Most auctions are competitive.** Keep opening principles in mind.

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Known Problems

- **1** - 3rd/4th seat 1NT is 15-17 HCP (not 12-14), because a weak NT blocks us without a chance at game. After a 3rd-seat suit opening, the NT rebid shows 12-14 balanced.
- **2** - The 4441 distribution. Every system struggles with this.
- **3** - 1♠ usually promises 5 spades, but with a strong 4333 hand it may show only 4 - which feels awkward.
- **4** - New defensive bidding package (CRASH, Michaels, Lebensohl) is adopted but untested at the table. See H-7 for the effectiveness tracking plan.

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The Central Idea

Every 1-level suit opening promises 5+ cards.

With extra strength (15-17 balanced), opener may hold only 4 cards and escapes to NT on the next bid, or makes a reverse (16+ HCP).

*So while the opening may show 4 cards, always think **5 by default**.*

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Openings

1NT

1st/2nd seat: 12-14 HCP - shape 4333 / 4432 / 5332 (5332 includes a 5-card major).

3rd seat: 15-17 HCP - shape 4333 / 4432 / 5332.

Stronger range in 3rd seat. With a weak 12-14 hand we risk blocking ourselves from game when partner passed with 11.

Responses to 1NT

- **2♣** - Puppet Stayman - asks for a 5-card major
- **2♦** - Transfer to ♥
- **2♥** - Transfer to ♠
- **2♠** - Transfer to ♣
- **3♣** - Transfer to ♦

Puppet Stayman Continuations

After 2♣, opener replies:

- **2♦** - Denies 5-card major
- **2♥** - 5 hearts
- **2♠** - 5 spades

After 2♣ - 2♦ (denial), responder continues:

- **2♥** - 4 spades (not 4 hearts). Opener bids 2♠ with a fit, 2NT without.
- **2♠** - 4 hearts (not 4 spades). Opener bids 3♥ with a fit, 2NT without.
- **2NT** - No 4-card major, invitational
- **3NT** - No 4-card major, game values

*After the denial, responder's major bids are **transfer-like**: 2♥ shows spades, 2♠ shows hearts. This lets the strong hand (opener) become declarer.*

Opener completes transfers normally. With maximum (13-14) and 4-card support, opener may super-accept by jumping to 3 of the major (see H-4).

Escaping 1NTx - Helvic Wriggle

After 1NT - (X):

- **XX** - One-suited hand. Opener bids 2♣, responder passes or corrects.
- **2♣** - ♣ + ♦ (touching pairs)
- **2♦** - ♦ + ♥ (touching pairs)
- **2♥** - ♥ + ♠ (touching pairs)
- **Pass** - To play, or will bid later

After Pass - Pass - **XX** = SOS with non-touching pairs (♣+♥ or ♦+♠). Opener bids 2♣, responder passes or corrects.

- **Weak, shapely** - Wriggle (escape to a suit fit)
- **Weak, balanced** - Pass (hope for the best)
- **Strong (10+ HCP)** - Pass - penalty. Thank them for doubling.

If opponents doubled, they show 15+ HCP. If responder has 10+, our side has 22+ combined - the opponents made a mistake. Pass and collect the penalty.

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1♣ / 1♦ / 1♥ / 1♠

1st/2nd seat: 12+ HCP, 5+ cards (4+ with extra strength and NT escape). LTC: 7 losers typical (range 5-8).

- With two 4-card suits, open the lower one first.
- With 15-17 balanced, open 4 cards and rebid NT.
- A 2NT rebid confirms 4 cards (not 5) in the opening suit.

3rd seat: 8+ HCP, 5+ cards (may be lighter than 1st/2nd seat). This is a passed-hand opening. Partner already passed, so there is no risk of missing game. The lighter range is tactical - competing for the partscore and directing the lead.

Continuations

- **1x - 2x (single raise)** - 6-9 HCP, 3+ card support. Standard. If opener had only 4, he rebids 2NT. - 9-10 losers
- **1x - 3x (limit raise)** - 10-12 HCP, 4+ card support. Invitational. Opener bids game with 5-6 losers. - 7-8 losers
- **1M - 4M (game raise)** - Distributional, 5+ card support or strong hand. Based on playing tricks, not just HCP. - 6-7 losers

After a fit is found, re-evaluate using LTC: 24 minus combined losers = expected tricks. A hand with 10 HCP but 7 losers (e.g. ♠:KQxxx ♥:x ♦:Axxx ♣:xxx) is a limit raise by LTC, though HCP says only a single raise. Trust LTC in suit contracts - see H-8.

Competitive Re-evaluation with LTC

When opponents intervene after our suit opening, both partners must re-evaluate using LTC, not just HCP. The auction (1♥) - 2♠ - ? asks responder: 'How many losers do I have in support of partner's suit?' A hand with 10 HCP and 9 losers should pass; a hand with 9 HCP and 7 losers should compete to 3♥.

- **Compete to the 2-level** - 16+ (8 tricks) - Free bid at the 2-level shows values; LTC confirms it's safe.
- **Compete to the 3-level** - 15 (9 tricks) - Law of Total Tricks applies here - with 9 trumps, bid to 3.
- **Bid game despite interference** - 14 or fewer (10+ tricks) - Don't let opponents push you out of game.
- **Double (penalty-oriented)** - - Prefer double when you hold 2+ defensive tricks and a misfit.

At favorable vulnerability, sacrifice when your combined LTC suggests you are outgunned. Going down 2 doubled non-vulnerable (-300) is better than letting them make game (+420/+620).

Sacrifice with 16+ combined losers at favorable; never at unfavorable.

1-Minor Opening, 1-Major Response

Key rule: *After 1♣ or 1♦, a response of 1♥ or 1♠ promises* ***5 cards*** *if weak. With invitational+ strength, may show only 4 (with a plan to rebid NT or raise). Therefore,* ***opener may support with just 3 cards!***

1NT Response

6-9 HCP, no fit (at most 3 cards), no 5-card major, no game ambitions. We may miss a 4-4 fit, but if we are weak the opponents will bid. If not, everyone has misfit or balanced - NT is the right spot. See hypothesis H-2 for forcing 1NT as a future improvement.

Opener's rebids after 1♣ - 1♥

- **1♠** - 4+ spades, any strength (not a reverse - still at the 1-level)
- **1NT** - 15-17 HCP, balanced (confirms 4-card ♣ opening)
- **2♣** - 6+ clubs, or 5 with extra strength
- **2♦** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ ♦ (forcing)
- **2♥** - Simple raise - 3+ ♥ support, not a reverse
- **2♠** - Reverse - 16+ HCP, 4+ ♠ (forcing)
- **2NT** - 18-19 HCP, balanced (confirms 4-card ♣ opening)
- **3♣** - 6+ clubs, invitational

Quick Reference

- **1♣ - 1♦** - Natural, 4+ diamonds, waiting
- **1♣ - 1♥/♠** - 5+ if weak; 4+ if strong (invitational+)

2♣ - Semi-Strong (Benji)

Type 1 - Balanced

22-23 HCP: 2♣ - 2♦ - 2NT

Type 2 - Strong Major (Acol-style)

2♣ - 2♦ - 2♥/♠

- About 5 losers
- At least 5 cards in the suit (usually 6+)
- At least 3 top honours (A, K, Q)
- Partner needs roughly 2 fillers to make game

Type 3 - Reserved

Under investigation for strong two-suiters (18-21, 5-5+). See hypothesis H-6.

Responses to 2♣

- **2♦** - Waiting (0-7 HCP)
- **2♥** - Positive relay - balanced, no 5-card suit, 8+ HCP
- **2♠** - 5+ spades, 8+ HCP
- **2NT** - 5+ hearts, 8+ HCP
- **3♣ / 3♦** - 5+ clubs/diamonds, game-force, slam interest opposite 22-23

All non-2♦ responses are game-forcing (8+ HCP). This avoids the problem where after 2♣ - 2♦ - 2♥, responder cannot show a 5-card major.

2♦ - Strong Game-Force

LTC: 3-4 losers (game in hand or near it)

Responder shows **controls** (Controls (Ace = 2, King = 1)):

- **2♥** - 0-1
- **2♠** - 2
- **2NT** - 3
- **3♣** - 4
- **3♦** - 5
- **3♥** - 6

Excellent for slam exploration. Opener immediately knows the combined control count and can place the contract or ask further.

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2♥ / 2♠ - Weak Two

6-10 HCP, 6+ cards. Disciplined, especially when vulnerable. LTC: 8-9 losers.
Suit quality: At least 2 of the top 5 honours (A, K, Q, J, T).
- 6+ cards in the bid major
- 6-10 HCP (not less, not more)
- Decent suit quality - partner may raise pre-emptively or try for game
- Avoid opening a weak two with a void or a strong 4-card side suit

Ogust (2NT asks) - __

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2NT - 20-21 HCP

Shape: 4333 / 4432 / 5332.

Responses to 2NT

- **3♣** - Puppet Stayman - asks for 5-card major
- **3♦** - Transfer to ♥
- **3♥** - Transfer to ♠
- **4NT** - Quantitative (inviting 6NT)

After 3♣, opener replies: 3♦ = denies 5-card major, then check for 4-card fits, 3♥ = 5 hearts, 3♠ = 5 spades.

Puppet Stayman fits better over 2NT than 1NT: the auction is already at the 3-level, so information leakage matters less, and finding the right major-suit game matters more.

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3-level and Above

- **3♣ / 3♦ / 3♥ / 3♠** - Preemptive - Destructive block. Sound at unfavourable vulnerability., 7+ cards, ~5-10 HCP, LTC: 7-8 losers (favorable: 8-9; unfavorable: 7)
- **3NT** - Gambling - AKQxxxx+ in a minor, no outside A or K
- **4♥ / 4♠** - To play - strong distributional hand or preemptive
- **4♣ / 4♦** - Strong preempt (8+ card minor, some values)
- **5♣ / 5♦** - Extreme preempt or to play

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Defensive Bidding

Vulnerability-Adjusted Losing Trick Count

All defensive bidding actions are governed by Losing Trick Count (LTC) adjusted for vulnerability. HCP gives a rough guide, but LTC measures offensive potential - the number of tricks your hand can contribute. Vulnerability determines how aggressive you can afford to be: cheap penalties at favorable allow lighter action; expensive penalties at unfavorable demand discipline.

- **Favorable** - We are Not Vulnerable, they are Vulnerable (NV vs Vul)
- **Equal** - Both Vulnerable or both Not Vulnerable
- **Unfavorable** - We are Vulnerable, they are Not Vulnerable (Vul vs NV)

At favorable vulnerability, act with 1 more loser than standard (the penalty for going down is cheap: 50/trick undoubled). At unfavorable vulnerability, require 1 fewer loser than standard (the penalty is expensive: 100/trick undoubled, 200+ doubled). At equal vulnerability, use standard thresholds.

LTC Reference Table

- **Simple overcall** - 9 losers - 8 losers - 7 losers
- **Jump overcall (weak)** - 10 losers - 9 losers - 8 losers
- **Takeout double** - 7 losers - 6 losers - 5 losers
- **CRASH / CRASH vs 1NT** - 9 losers, 5-4+ shape - 8 losers, 5-4+ shape - 7 losers, 5-5+ shape
- **Michaels / Unusual 2NT** - 9 losers (weak side) - 8 losers (weak side) - 7 losers or 16+ HCP (strong side only)
- **RAPTOR 1NT overcall** - 9 losers - 8 losers - 7 losers
- **Natural overcall at 2-level** - 8 losers - 7 losers - 6 losers

Overcalls

- **Simple overcall** - 8-16 HCP, 5++ cards. Suit quality matters more than HCP. A 5-card suit headed by two honours with 8 losers is a sound overcall. Assess tricks, not points. LTC: 8 losers at equal; 9 at favorable; 7 at unfavorable.
- **Jump overcall** - Weak - same as a weak two/three opening at the appropriate level - same as a weak two/three opening at the appropriate level. LTC: 9 losers at equal; 10 at favorable; 8 at unfavorable.
- **Takeout double** - Support for all unbid suits, typically 12+ HCP or any 17+. LTC: 6 losers at equal (shape compensates for fewer HCP with good support).

RAPTOR Convention

An overcall of **1NT** over opponent's suit opening shows:
- **4 cards in the unbid major**
- **5+ cards in a minor**
- **10-16 HCP**

We bid using the **minimax principle** (minimax - aiming to sign off, tolerate a suit). Comes up more frequently than a natural 1NT (15-17) overcall. The HCP range is 10-16 because lighter hands pass and stronger hands start with a takeout double. LTC is more accurate than HCP here because the 4-5+ two-suited shape generates tricks.

After Opponent Opens 1♥ or 1♠

Shows: 4 in unbid major + 5+ in a minor.

- **Cue bid (opponent's suit)** - Asks for the major

- **2 of other minor** - To play
- **2 of unbid major** - Natural, 5+ cards, willing to play
- **2NT** - Invitational+, asks overcaller's shape

After Opponent Opens 1♣ or 1♦

Shows: 5+ in other minor + 4 in an unknown major.

- **2♣ (cheapest minor)** - Pass or correct to overcaller's minor
- **Cue bid (opponent's suit)** - Asks for the major
- **2♥ / 2♠** - Natural, 5+ cards
- **2NT** - Invitational+, asks overcaller's shape

CRASH Convention

Trigger: Opponents open strong 1♣, 2♣, 2♦, or short club (2+)

When opponents open an artificial/strong bid that does not promise a specific suit, all four suits are 'unbid'. CRASH provides three two-suited bids organized by suit-pairing property: Color, Rank, Shape.

- **Color** - Two same-color suits (♥+♦ reds, or ♠+♣ blacks)
- **Rank** - Two same-rank suits (♥+♠ majors, or ♣+♦ minors)
- **Shape** - Two same-shape suits (♠+♦ pointed, or ♥+♣ rounded)
- 5-4+ shape (5-5+ required at unfavorable vulnerability)
- LTC: 8 losers at equal, 9 at favorable, 7 at unfavorable
- At unfavorable: only act with 5-5+ shape and 7 or fewer losers
- At favorable: 5-4 shape with 9 losers is acceptable - disruption value is high

vs Strong 2♣: (2♣) - ?

- **X** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **2♦** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **2♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades
- **2NT** - Shape (pointed or rounded)

CRASH Defense to 1NT (differentiated by strength)

Unified CRASH framework extends to 1NT defense. Against weak NT, a penalty double is too valuable to sacrifice (opponents are minimum, conversion is frequent). Against strong NT, disruption via CRASH is more productive than penalty. After a penalty double, if opponents run, revert to natural bidding.

Vs Strong NT (15-17)

Trigger: (1NT: 15-17) - ?

- **X** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **2♣** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **2♦** - Shape (pointed or rounded)
- **2♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades

Pure CRASH. No penalty double - against 15-17, we are unlikely to have a big penalty. Disruption and lead direction are more valuable.

Vs Weak NT (12-14)

Trigger: (1NT: 12-14) - ?

- **X** - Penalty (15+ HCP)
- **2♣** - Color (reds or blacks)
- **2♦** - Rank (majors or minors)
- **2♥** - Natural, 5+ hearts
- **2♠** - Natural, 5+ spades
- **2NT** - Shape (pointed or rounded)

CRASH shifts one step up to make room for penalty double. Shape moves to 2NT. Against 12-14, the penalty double is high-frequency and lucrative - opponents are minimum and unlikely to make 1NT doubled.

After penalty double: Natural bidding resumes. No CRASH, no special meanings.

- -

Michaels Cuebid

Trigger: Direct cuebid of opponent's natural suit opening

Over Minor: (1♣) - 2♣ or (1♦) - 2♦

Shows: Both majors (5-5+)

- **2♥ / 2♠** - To play (preference)
- **2NT** - Asks for minor; game interest
- **3♥ / 3♠** - Invitational (4+ card support)
- **4♥ / 4♠** - To play

Over Major: (1♥) - 2♥ or (1♠) - 2♠

Shows: Other major + unspecified minor (5-5+)

- **2♠ (or 2♥)** - To play in the other major
- **2NT** - Asks which minor (3♣ = clubs, 3♦ = diamonds)
- **3♣** - Pass or correct (to play in overcaller's minor)
- **3 of other major** - Invitational
- **4 of other major** - To play

Unusual 2NT

Trigger: Jump to 2NT over opponent's 1-level suit opening

Shows: Two lowest unbid suits (5-5+)

Range: Same as Michaels: weak (8-9 losers) or strong (5-6 losers)

Lebensohl

Trigger: Partner doubles opponent's weak two (2♥ or 2♠) for takeout

Without Lebensohl, advancer cannot distinguish weak (0-7), invitational (8-11), and game-forcing (12+) hands. The 2NT relay creates a weak channel; direct bids become constructive. Slow Shows, Fast Denies resolves the 3NT stopper question.

- **2NT** - Relay to 3♣ (weak hand, 0-7 HCP, 10+ losers)
- **direct 3-level suit** - Invitational (8-11 HCP), natural, non-forcing
- **cuebid (3 of their suit)** - Game-forcing, asks for stopper in opponent's suit
- **direct 3NT** - To play, denies stopper in their suit (Fast Denies)
- **2NT then 3NT (after relay)** - To play, shows stopper in their suit (Slow Shows)

Defensive Carding

Use your head first, not partner's signals. In most situations, the bidding and dummy tell you everything. Signals are a last resort.

1. Attitude (Encourage / Discourage) (Encourage / Discourage)

- **Low card** - Encouraging - continue this suit
- **High card** - Discouraging - please switch

Exception: When partner leads the Ace, give count (even/odd) instead of attitude. If partner wants continuation from AK, he leads the King.

2. Count (Even / Odd) (Even / Odd)

- **High card** - Even number of cards
- **Low card** - Odd number of cards

Easy to remember: From a doubleton (even), play high.

3. Suit Preference on Discards (Italian Style) on Discards

- **Odd card (3, 5, 7, 9)** - Interest in the suit being discarded
- **Low even card (2, 4)** - Interest in the lower-ranking side suit
- **High even card (6, 8)** - Interest in the higher-ranking side suit

Signalling by Elimination

- **4 then 2** - Denies interest in the lower suit
- **9 then 3** - Denies interest in the discarded suit
- **8 then 6** - Denies interest in the higher suit

The higher the discard, the less reliable. The second discard confirms.

4. Opening Leads

Lead 3rd or 5th highest from length.

Vs suits: Prefer top-of-sequence leads. Avoid leading from unsupported honours into declarer's strength.

Vs NT: Lead your longest suit unless the bidding clearly shows opponents hold it.

From Length

- **K95** - 5 - 3rd highest
- **KQ752** - 2 - 5th highest

From Sequences

- **AKx(x)** - K (A asks for count)
- **KQx(x)** - K
- **QJx(x)** - Q
- **JTx(x)** - J
- **T9x(x)** - T
- **AKQx(x)** - A (then K - showing the sequence)

From Short Holdings

- **xx** - Higher card
- **xxx** - Middle, then high (MUD)
- **xxxx** - Highest safe, then low

Special rule: *If you hold the J, lead 4th highest. Example: from KJ732, lead the 3 (not the 2).*

Additional Materials - Hand Evaluation

High Card Points are the lingua franca of bridge, but HCP alone misjudge distributional hands, honour placement, and fit quality. A complete evaluation combines HCP with distributional adjustments, Losing Trick Count, controls, working honours, and suit quality.

Milton Work Point Count

- **Ace** - 4
- **King** - 3
- **Queen** - 2
- **Jack** - 1

Total deck: **40** HCP.

Guidelines

opening: 12+ HCP (or Rule of 20)

game major: ~25 combined HCP with 8+ fit

game minor: ~28-29 combined HCP

game nt: ~25 combined HCP with stoppers

slam small: ~33 combined HCP

slam grand: ~37 combined HCP

Treats all aces as equal - A opposite KQJ is better than A opposite xxx

Ignores distribution entirely

Overvalues unsupported honours (singleton K, doubleton Q)
Ignores intermediates (tens, nines)

Distributional Adjustments

Distribution creates tricks beyond HCP. There are two schools: length points (Goren original) count long suits before a fit is found; shortness points (Karpin/Bergen) count short suits after a fit is found. Both capture the same truth: shape generates tricks.

Length Points (Goren)

Add 1 point per card beyond four in any suit

- **5-card suit** - 1
- **6-card suit** - 2
- **7-card suit** - 3

Shortness Points (Dummy Points)

When raising partner's suit, add points for shortness

- **Void** - 5
- **Singleton** - 3
- **Doubleton** - 1

Warning: *Do not count shortness points when you are the declarer or when the short suit contains wasted honours (Qx, Jx).*

Bergen's Rule of 20

Add HCP + length of two longest suits. If total >= 20, open the bidding.

- **♠:AQxxx ♥:KJxxx ♦:xx ♣:x** - 11 - 5+5=10 - 21 - Open
- **♠:AQxx ♥:KJx ♦:Qxx ♣:xxx** - 12 - 4+3=7 - 19 - Pass (flat shape, poor controls)

Working vs Wasted Honours

Honours in partner's suits and in your long suits generate tricks. Honours in short suits or in opponent's suits are wasted.

- **Honour in partner's suit** - +1 (the honour is working)
- **Honour in opponent's bid suit** - -1 (likely not pulling weight on offense)
- **Singleton honour (K, Q, J alone)** - -2 (cannot develop tricks, may be captured)
- **Doubleton honour (Qx, Jx)** - -1 (needs partner's help to be worth anything)
- **Aces and Kings** - Always working - they take tricks regardless

Control Count

- **Ace** - 2
- **King** - 1

An average hand has 4 controls. Hands with 5+ controls are slam-oriented; hands with 3 or fewer are defensive.

The Italian school (Blue Team) valued controls over HCP for slam bidding. A hand with 14 HCP but only 2 controls (two kings, no aces) is dangerous at the 5-level. A hand with 12 HCP and 5 controls (two aces + one king) is a powerful slam hand.

Honour Combinations and Intermediates

Honours working together generate tricks. AKQ in one suit is worth more than A, K, Q spread across three suits. Intermediates (T, 9) fill out suits and prevent losers.

- **AKJTx** - Almost certainly 5 tricks - the T fills beautifully
- **AKxxx** - Only 3 sure tricks - needs 3-2 break for 4
- **QJT9x** - Self-sufficient opposite any doubleton - 3 tricks likely
- **Qxxxx** - Generates tricks only with partner's help

Suit Quality Test (SQT)

SQT = suit length + number of honour cards (A, K, Q, J, T) in the suit

A suit is biddable at the N-level if SQT >= N + number of tricks you need. Useful for overcalls, preempts, and competitive decisions.

- **KQJ9xxx** - 11 - SQT 11 - strong enough for a 3-level preempt at any vulnerability
- **Qxxxxx** - 7 - SQT 7 - marginal for a 2-level weak two; fine at favorable
- **AKJTx** - 9 - SQT 9 - excellent 5-card overcall suit
- **Jxxxx** - 6 - SQT 6 - do not overcall with this suit

Adjust-3 (Quick Revaluation)

After a fit is found, add 1 point for each trump beyond the eighth, add 1 for a side singleton, add 1 for a side void, and subtract 1 for each flat-hand indicator (4333).

Playing Tricks vs Defensive Tricks

A hand has playing tricks (tricks it can take as declarer) and defensive tricks (tricks it can take defending). Distributional hands have many playing tricks but few defensive. Balanced hands have defensive tricks but limited playing tricks.

- Aces and kings are both playing and defensive
- Long suits add playing tricks but not defensive
- Queens and jacks in short suits add defensive tricks but not playing
- Voids add playing tricks (via ruffs) but zero defensive

This distinction matters in competitive auctions. When deciding 'bid or double', count your defensive tricks. If you have 2 or fewer defensive tricks, bidding is usually right. If you have 4+, doubling pays better.

Evaluation Tools Summary

- **HCP** - Opening bids, NT ranges, first approximation - Ignores distribution
- **Distributional points** - Suit contracts, revaluation after fit - Meaningless in NT
- **Rule of 20** - Marginal opening decisions - Doesn't account for vulnerability or seat
- **Working honours** - Revaluation during the auction - Requires information from bidding
- **Controls** - Slam evaluation - Ignores suit quality
- **SQT** - Overcalls, preempts, competitive bids - Suit-specific, not whole-hand
- **Losing Trick Count** - Suit contracts, competitive decisions, slam tries - Unreliable in NT; assumes a trump fit

Additional Materials - Losing Trick Count

The Losing Trick Count evaluates hand strength by counting losers - cards that will not win tricks even in the best case. It is more accurate than HCP for suit contracts, especially for distributional hands and competitive decisions. The formula: 24 minus combined losers equals the number of tricks the partnership can expect.

How to Count Losers

Examine only the top three cards in each suit. Each missing top honour (Ace, King, Queen) in the top three is one loser. A void has 0 losers. A singleton has at most 1 loser. A doubleton has at most 2 losers.

- **Void** - 0
- **Singleton** - 1
- **Doubleton** - 2
- **3+ cards** - 3

Standard LTC - Losers per Holding

- **-** - 0 - Void
- **A** - 0 -
- **K** - 1 - Singleton K counts as 1 (may be captured)
- **Q** - 1 - Singleton Q counts as 1 (usually lost)
- **x** - 1 - Small singleton
- **AK** - 0 -
- **AQ** - 0.5 - Half loser (finesse dependent)
- **Ax** - 1 -
- **KQ** - 1 -
- **Kx** - 1 -
- **Qx** - 2 - Very likely both lost without help
- **xx** - 2 -
- **AKQ** - 0 -
- **AKx** - 1 -
- **AQx** - 1 - Half loser rounded up; finesse for Q
- **Axx** - 2 -
- **KQx** - 1 -
- **Kxx** - 2 -
- **Qxx** - 2.5 - The queen rarely takes a trick without support
- **xxx** - 3 - Maximum losers for any holding

Combined Loser Count → Expected Tricks

24 minus (opener's losers + responder's losers) = expected tricks

- **7** - 9 - 16 - 8 - 2-level (partscore)
- **7** - 7 - 14 - 10 - 4-level (game in major)
- **5** - 7 - 12 - 12 - 6-level (small slam)
- **4** - 7 - 11 - 13 - 7-level (grand slam)

Cover Cards

A cover card is a card that covers one of partner's losers - typically an ace or king in the right suit. When partner opens and you hold fitting honours, count cover cards rather than HCP to decide whether to bid game or slam.

Partner opens 1♠ showing 5+ spades. You hold ♠:Kxxx ♥:Axx ♦:xxxx ♣:xx (9 HCP, 9 losers). Count cover cards for partner's likely hand: the ♠:K covers one spade loser, the ♥:A covers a heart loser - 2 cover cards. If partner has 7 losers, combined = 14 - 2 = 12 tricks? No - the loser count method is more accurate. 24 - (7+9) = 8 tricks. But if partner's 7-loser hand has specific losers in hearts and spades, your covers are perfectly placed.

Typical Loser Count by Common Bidding Actions

- **Open at the 1-level** - 7 (range 5-8)
- **Minimum response (6-9 HCP)** - 9-10
- **Invitational raise (10-12)** - 8
- **Game-forcing response (12+)** - 7 or fewer
- **Preemptive opening (weak two)** - 8-9
- **Preemptive opening (3-level)** - 8-9 (7+ card suit)
- **Strong 2♣ opening** - 4-5
- **Strong 2♦ opening (game force)** - 3-4
- **Overcall (simple)** - 7-8
- **Takeout double** - 6 (shape compensates)

Ron Klinger's Queen Adjustments

Standard LTC overvalues queens. Klinger suggested adjustments: a guarded queen (Qxx+) in a bid suit is worth half a loser less; a singleton or doubleton queen is worth nothing.

- **Qxx+ in partner's bid suit** - Subtract 0.5 losers
- **Qxx+ in your own long suit** - Subtract 0.5 losers
- **Singleton Q** - Count as 1 full loser (same as singleton x)
- **Doubleton Qx** - Count as 2 losers (queen is unlikely to take a trick)

New Losing Trick Count (Koelman)

NLTC refines the standard count by weighting losers: an ace loser (missing the ace) costs more than a queen loser (missing the queen), because aces take tricks independently while queens need support.

- **Ace** - 1.5
- **King** - 1.0
- **Queen** - 0.5

26 minus combined NLTC losers = expected tricks

Reliability and Limitations

Works well for:

- Suit contracts with an 8+ card trump fit
- Competitive decisions (bid vs pass vs double)
- Slam exploration in suit contracts
- Evaluating distributional hands that HCP undervalue

Unreliable for:

- Notrump contracts (distribution doesn't generate ruffs)
- Misfits (no 8-card fit; losers don't cancel)
- Very short suits opposite very long suits (duplication)
- Hands where the opponents' lead kills a critical entry

LTC vs HCP Decision Guide

- **Opening the bidding** - HCP (Rule of 20 for borderline) - LTC requires a fit to be meaningful
- **Raising partner's suit** - LTC - Fit is confirmed; LTC measures playing strength
- **Notrump bidding** - HCP - LTC assumes ruffs; NT relies on high cards and stoppers
- **Competitive decisions** - LTC - Distributional hands overbid by LTC less than by HCP
- **Slam investigation** - LTC (NLTC for precision) - Controls and playing tricks matter, not scattered queens
- **Penalty doubles** - HCP + defensive tricks - You need quick tricks, not playing tricks